

Three Minds Began Hall Of Fame

By FLIP MORIN
Times Sports Writer

It was 21 years ago that Chuck Whitlock, Bob Ingram and John Phelan conjured up the El Paso Athletic Hall of Fame idea. For that first enshrinement they only had two categories — living and posthumous athlete.

Sports around El Paso has naturally grown and so has the Hall of Fame. This year (7:30 p.m. Tuesday in the Civic Center) the Eastwood High School basketball team, University of Texas at El Paso track teams plus seven individual athletes will be honored. The newest category, sports media, will find Whitlock joining Ingram and Phelan on the list of honorees.

The whole thing came about in 1955 as Whitlock (El Paso Times), Ingram (Herald Post) and Phelan (KTSM Radio) were rapping in the Press Club of those days, located under what is now Joe Borzi's at Kansas and Franklin. "The city already had its Gridiron Shows which spoofed civic and sports figures," Whitlock said. "So we thought it was time for El Paso to recognize our athletes with something. The Texas School of Mines had its

annual banquet, but that was about all."

They came up with the Hall of Fame idea, and contacted Chris Fox of the State National Bank, who could always be counted on to advance noteworthy El Paso projects. They were on their way.

"That first year we inducted Andy Cohen," Whitlock said. "We held all our banquets at the old Hilton, which is now the Plaza Hotel," Whitlock recalls. "Incidentally, Andy is a one-of-a-kind major league baseball manager because he is the only person to never lose a game."

It seems Cohen was a coach for the Phillies back in 1960. The club manager, Eddie Sawyer, had lost a game to Cincinnati the day before, so he up and quit. Cohen was called to manage the team and they beat Milwaukee in 10 innings. "So Andy is in the books as being the only major league manager to have a perfect win-loss record," Whitlock said.

"He was our first inductee, along with N. A. Ferguson."

The second banquet turned out to be a blooper for the trio, as Margaret Varner, a world-chess tennis and squash player, was their honoree. "We held the enshrinement the same night as the annual Gridiron Show was staged," Whitlock said. "In those days Polly Harris and Art Leibson were the ramrods, and they really came up with some zippy material. We went to the show after our sports banquet and Margaret, her parents and friends walked out."

The Gridiron shows were traditionally "stag" events, and almost anything went in those days.

"Sports in those first years consisted of golf, baseball and the Golden Gloves boxing," Whitlock pointed out. "There wasn't any racing and the School of Mines had football. There were only four high schools."

One of the most embarrassing banquets was in 1959. "Our guest speaker was Frank Leahy, coach at Notre Dame," he said. "Only he didn't show up until late in the evening. He went to the Airport Hilton instead of the downtown Hilton, that was the year Jack Harden was inducted."

One year golf professional Bob Rosburg didn't show up at all to address the guests.

"It has grown to really something now," Whitlock

noted. "The only thing missing, and we hope someone comes up with an idea soon, is for a permanent hall to display all the photos and accomplishments of these fine athletes we have in El Paso."

The first Hall of Fame was a sellout, as was the 1961 event honoring Willie Shoemaker, the winningest jockey ever, from Fabens. The old Press Club is long gone but sports nostalgia will be re-kindled Tuesday, sellout or not.

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